

On Libraries

~ Oliver Sacks

- Understanding the text

Answer the following questions.

a) ~~that~~ Where could the author be found when he was late for lunch or dinner?

Ans Whenever the author was late for lunch or dinner, he was almost certainly found in the library. He became so deeply absorbed in his reading that the ~~passenger~~ passage of time meant nothing to him. For the author, the intellectual sanctuary of the library provided far more satisfaction than any meal. He prioritized the discovery of new ideas and stories over his daily physical needs, often losing track of his surrounding while completely engrossed in books.

b) What are his first memories?

Ans His earliest memories are intrinsically linked to books and the act of reading. Long before he started formal schooling, he recalls the comfort and fascination he felt while surrounded by printed pages. These memories do not center on specific people or events, but rather the quiet joy of discovery and the sense of wonder that books instilled in him. This early exposure to literature became the foundation for his lifelong intellectual curiosity and passion for learning.

c) Why did he dislike school?

Ans. The author disliked school because he found the formal education system rigid, mechanical and restrictive. He felt the curriculum forced students to memorize facts rather than genuinely understand them, which stifled his natural curiosity. The classroom environment failed to cater to his personal interests, making learning feel like an exhausting chore. He preferred the freedom of self-directed study, where he could explore topics deeply without being constrained by syllabus demands or the pressure of academic performance.

d) What did he feel about at the library?

Ans. At the library, the author felt a profound sense of freedom, peace and belonging. It served as a private sanctuary where he could escape the pressures of the outside world and the monotony of school. He viewed the library as an expansive, limitless treasure trove of knowledge that empowered him to follow his own intellectual path. In this quiet environment, he felt fully alive, intellectually stimulated, and comfortable in his own ~~for~~ pursuit of understanding the universe.

e) Why was he so biased about sciences especially astronomy and chemistry?

Ans. He was biased towards chemistry and astronomy because these fields felt like keys

to unlocking the mysteries of the universe. He was captivated by the tangible "magic" of chemical reactions and the vast, awe-inspiring scale of the cosmos. Unlike abstract subjects that felt disconnected from reality, science provided him with concrete explanations for how the world functioned. This deep-seated desire to comprehend the fundamental "how" and "why" of existence fueled his intense passion for these specific disciplines.

f) Why did he become so fascinated by Hooke?

Ans. The author became fascinated by Hooke because he embodied the spirit of the inquisitive, observant scientist. Hooke's ability to peer into the microscopic world and his mechanical ingenuity mirrored the author's own desire to look beyond the surface of things. Hooke represented a hero of discovery - a man who relentlessly questioned and documented the world around him. This dedication to finding hidden truths resonated deeply with the author's personal approach to learning and exploration.

g) Describe library at the Queen's College.

Ans. The library at Queen's College was a grand, atmospheric space characterized by its reverence for knowledge. It featured towering dusty bookshelves that seemed to stretch indefinitely, housing an immense collection of human thought. The air was heavy with the scent of old paper.

and silence, creating an environment that encouraged slow, deliberate exploration. It felt like a physical bridge to the past, providing a serene, scholarly sanctuary that invited students to wander, reflect, and discovery hidden intellectual gems.

h) Why did the students ignore the bookshelves in the 1990s?

Ans. In the 1990s, students began ignoring physical bookshelves due to the rapid advancement of digital technology. As the internet and computerized databases became more accessible, students prioritized the speed and convenience of digital information over the traditional method of browsing through dusty stacks. The library transitioned from a place for quiet ~~can~~ contemplation ~~of~~ and discovery to a utilitarian space for computer use. Consequently, the act of physically searching for books felt outdated compared to the efficiency of digital retrieval.

i) Why was he horrified when he visited the library a couple of months ago?

Ans. He was horrified because the library had undergone a sterile transformation that prioritized modern convenience over its traditional character. Many of the original bookshelves had been removed or replaced, disrupting the intimate, scholarly atmosphere he had cherished for years. Seeing his beloved sanctuary turned into a modernized, soulless spa-

ce felt like a loss of history. To the author, this change represented a betrayal of the quiet, tactile experience that made the library a true home for knowledge.

- Reference to the content

a) The author says, "I was not a good pupil, but I was a good learner." Justify it with the textual evidences.

Ans The author's distinction between being a "good pupil" and a "good learner" highlights the conflict between institutional requirements and genuine intellectual curiosity. As a pupil, he struggled within the school system, finding the rigid structure, rote memorization, and standard curriculum dull and restrictive. He felt that classrooms stifled his natural desire to explore, making him appear as an indifferent student who failed to conform to the expectations of his teachers & peers.

However, as a learner, his passion for knowledge was immense and self-driven. He spent his time independently exploring complex subjects like chemistry and astronomy, often losing track of time in the library. This dedication shows that his lack of interest in school was not a lack of intelligence, but a rejection of a system that didn't foster real inquiry. He thrived when he was free to investigate the world on his own terms.

ultimately, the author proves that being a "good learner" is about the internal drive to discover, not the ability to follow a syllabus. His ability to master difficult topics through solitary reading in the library demonstrates a deep, extraordinary capacity for knowledge. While he failed at the mechanical tasks of a pupil, his success as an autodidact confirms that his thirst for understanding was always vibrant and effective.

b) A proverb says, "Nothing is pleasanter than exploring a library." Does this proverb apply in the essay? Explain.

Ans This proverb is the heartbeat of the essay, perfectly reflecting the author's relationship with the library. Throughout the text, the library serves as his most cherished sanctuary, a place where he escapes the pressures of academic life and finds genuine happiness. He portrays the act of wandering through the shelves not just as a task, but as a deeply satisfying adventure that provides him with both comfort and intellectual liberation.

For the author, the library was the only place where he felt truly at peace. While his school days were marked by frustration and dislike, his time in the library was characterized by profound joy and discovery. He found immense pleasure in the silence of the aisles and the endless possibilities con-

tained within the dusty books. This environment nurtured his mind and allowed his ~~to~~ imagination to grow in ways that the classroom never could.

In conclusion, the essay acts as a testament to the truth of this proverb. By contrasting his miserable experiences at school with the intellectual delight he found among the books, the author confirms that the library is indeed a place of unmatched pleasure. It was more than just a room full of shelves; it was a living space where he could explore the vast landscape of human knowledge at his own place.

c) Are there any other services that you would like to ~~see~~ see added to the library?

Ans To ensure libraries remain essential in the modern age, they should evolve into dynamic "maker spaces." Adding resources like 3D printers, coding workstations, and high-tech media production studios would transform the library from a place of passive consumption into a hub of active creation. Such services would encourage students to bridge the gap between reading about theories and building their own innovative projects, making the library a center for practical, real-world learning.

Furthermore, libraries could offer more interac-

live community services to enhance the scholarly experience. Hosting regular workshops on digital literacy, advanced research techniques, and interdisciplinary discussions would help students navigate the overwhelming amount of information available today. By facilitating collaboration, these services would turn the library into a vibrant forum where ideas are shared and refined, rather than just a place to study in isolation.

Finally, integrating these modern tools would keep the library relevant for future generations. By blending the classic, quiet atmosphere of physical archives with the high-tech energy of creative studios, libraries can cater to all types of learners. This balance ensures that while we honor the history of books, we also equip students with the skills and inspiration needed to succeed in an ever-changing world.